



For Staff

## Student Discloses Abuse at Home

Responding when a student tells you, or shows you, that an adult at home has hurt them

### Content Warning

This guide covers physical abuse of children at home, injuries and fear of going home.

**This is reference guidance, not a training course.** Use it to check how to respond, or to prepare for a conversation. It does not replace the school's safeguarding training, policy or the DSL's advice on a specific case.

It contains descriptions of physical abuse by parents and carers, children's injuries, domestic abuse and emergency protection. Some of it may be difficult to read, particularly if it connects with your own experience or that of someone close to you.

- You can read it in sections, take a break, or step away at any point.
- If this raises something personal, you can speak in confidence to your line manager, a senior colleague you trust, or the school's Employee Assistance Programme, if it has one, or **Education Support** (free, confidential, 24/7 on 08000 562 561). The **NSPCC Helpline** (0800 800 5000) is there for any adult worried about a child.
- If you have a question about how this guidance applies to a situation you are dealing with, speak to your school's Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL).

**If reading this makes you worried about a child now, do not wait until you have finished reading: speak to the DSL or a deputy straight away. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.**

**Immediate danger or possible risk to life:** call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response. **Go to the Quick Reference Card.**

## Why This Matters

Physical abuse at home is common, and it is usually hidden. In the most recent national survey, **16.5% of adults in England and Wales (about 7.7 million people) said they had experienced physical abuse by an adult before the age of 18.** The people most often named as responsible were **fathers (45.6%) and mothers (37.2%)** ([ONS, November 2025](#)).

For many children, school is the one place where an adult outside the family sees them every day. **KCSIE 2026** says staff should act on concerns immediately (paragraph 58) and never promise a child they will not tell anyone (paragraph 14).

## Scenario Overview

**A Year 7 student stays behind after a lesson and tells you that their parent hit them with a belt last night because they got poor marks in a test. They pull up the leg of their trousers and show you marks on their legs.**

### What to Keep in Mind

- **This is a disclosure of physical abuse, and it needs action today.** Tell the DSL straight away, before the student goes home. You don't need to be certain, and you don't need to decide whether it is "bad enough".
- **Don't photograph or examine the marks,** and don't ask to see more.
- **Don't contact the parents yourself.**
- **Whether the student goes home today is a decision for the DSL,** with children's social care, made the same day and before the end of the school day where possible.
- **Other children may live in the same home.** Siblings, at this school or elsewhere, are part of the DSL's thinking.
- **Culture, faith, stress or high expectations may explain an adult's behaviour; they never excuse harm to a child.** Staff never decide whether an offence has been committed.
- The student may take it back, play it down, or defend the parent. That is common, and it does not change what you do.

## How RESPOND Works in This Scenario

RESPOND is powered by **ACT: Active Intervention** (inaction is not neutral: a child who shows you an injury is asking for help), **Contextual Safeguarding** (harm at home affects school, friendships and siblings, and may be triggered by school events such as test results) and **Trauma-Informed Practice** (safety before emotion before thinking). The steps are taught in order but work as a **helix**: see *The RESPOND Helix* section.

| Step               | RESPOND tool                                                | In this scenario                                                    |
|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ● <b>Recognise</b> | 4 Ps Context Scan; Escalation of Unseen Harm                | Injuries, fear of going home, anxiety about marks and reports       |
| ● <b>Engage</b>    | TED questions; the disclosure script                        | Listen, believe, and don't ask why. Don't ask leading questions     |
| ● <b>Support</b>   | Safety check first; "Your calm is contagious"               | Is it safe to go home today? Any injury needing first aid?          |
| ● <b>Pause</b>     | 90-second grounding; Three Lenses (Risk, Rights, Resources) | No photographs, no examination, no call to the parents, no promises |
| ● <b>Offer</b>     | Model alternatives; if in doubt, N before O                 | Tell the DSL first; then explain honestly what happens next         |
| ● <b>Notify</b>    | DSL, straight away, before the student goes home            | Same day referral decision; 999 if in immediate danger              |
| ● <b>Document</b>  | GOLD standard; body marks in words                          | Exact words, what you saw, where on the body, and what you did      |

**RESPOND is not a checklist to complete in order. Immediate danger or possible risk to life: act first (999 when needed, stay with the child, summon the DSL or a deputy), then return to the steps.**

**Need the essentials?** The *Quick Reference Card* at the end of this guide covers the immediate response and escalation on one page.

**The One Chance Rule:** a disclosure may be a young person's only attempt to seek help. Make it count.

## The RESPOND Helix: How the Steps Move

RESPOND is taught in a line, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. In practice it moves as a helix. The first dimension is the steps themselves: you may loop back, hold at a step, or go straight to Notify. The second is time and severity: each turn sits

higher as a concern develops. The third is context: a concern involving several children, places or platforms traces a wider spiral.

### Relational and Systemic

For a child, safeguarding is **relational**: it happens through people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: the steps, records and shared decisions that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help.

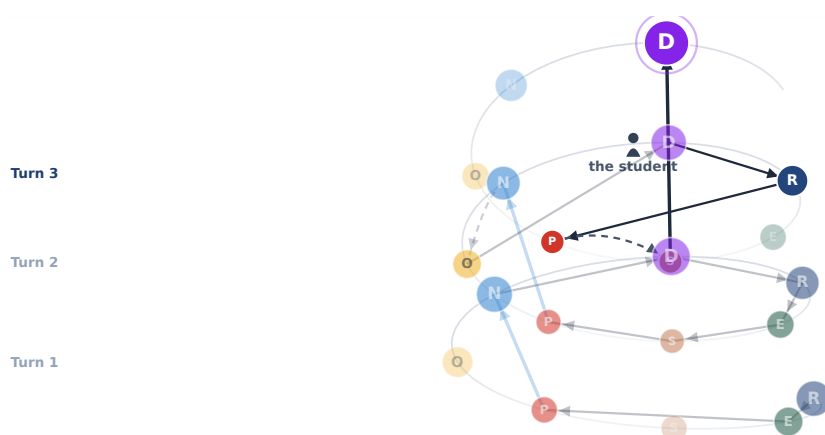
**Relational is why children tell. Systemic is why telling works.**

The RESPOND steps follow the same shape: Recognise, Engage and Support are relational; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps. Neither works alone. Relationship without the system becomes secrecy, which is why staff never promise to keep a disclosure to themselves. The system without relationship becomes process that children do not trust enough to use. When you share information, be open with the child about what you are sharing and why.

## See It Move

Two examples: a Year 7 student whose worry about marks builds over several weeks before they tell you, and a Year 9 student who is afraid to go home. Then see a wider spiral, where brothers and sisters are involved, and what happens when steps are skipped.

*This is a still image of the interactive RESPOND Helix. Open the web version of this guide to step through the examples; every example is also written out in full below.*



### ▼ Read the helix demonstration as text

#### Sequence

How RESPOND is taught.

1. **The seven steps:** RESPOND is taught in this order, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. Recognise, Engage and Support are the relational steps; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps.
2. **But practice is not a line:** Harm at home often shows itself in small signs before anyone says anything, and then a disclosure can move very fast. You may loop back, hold at a step, or go straight to Notify. Choose an example to see how the steps move.

### Small signs, then a disclosure

A Year 7 student over half a term: small signs, then a disclosure, then a decision about going home. The example is fictional.

1. **Turn 1: small signs:** A Year 7 student becomes very anxious before tests and says, "My dad will go mad if I get a bad mark." In PE they keep their tracksuit bottoms on and change alone. Recognise: use the 4 Ps. No single sign proves anything.
2. **Turn 1:** Engage: a quiet, kind check-in. TED: "Tell me how things are at home when you get your marks back." The student shrugs and says it's fine.
3. **Turn 1:** Pause: hold here. Don't push, don't ask leading questions such as "Does your dad hit you?", and don't contact home to ask.
4. **Turn 1:** Notify: pass the worry to the DSL through the school's usual system, today. Small signs only become a picture when they are shared.
5. **Turn 1:** Document: GOLD, with the student's exact words about their dad and what you noticed in PE.
6. **Turn 2: a disclosure (three weeks later):** After a test is handed back, the student stays behind, says their parent hit them with a belt last night because of the mark, and shows marks on their legs. Because the earlier worry was recorded, the DSL can see the pattern. You didn't need to wait for it to happen again: the first worry was right to share.
7. **Turn 2:** Engage: stay calm and use the script: "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next." Then TED only: "Tell me what happened." Never ask why.
8. **Turn 2:** Support: safety check first. Is the student hurt now, and do they need first aid? Are they worried about going home tonight? Don't examine the marks or photograph them.
9. **Turn 2:** Pause: 90 seconds, then Three Lenses. Don't promise secrecy, don't call the parent, and don't ask the student to show you any more.
10. **Turn 2: N before O:** Notify before Offer: take it to the DSL straight away, in person, before the end of the lesson change if you can. The student is not left alone while you do.
11. **Turn 2:** Offer, once the DSL has acted: explain honestly what happens next, give choices where there are choices, and show the student that adults respond to mistakes without hurting.
12. **Turn 2:** Document: GOLD, with the student's exact words, and the marks described in words: where on the body, size, shape and colour, as you saw them.
13. **Turn 3: a decision point:** By early afternoon the DSL has spoken to children's social care. The question now is whether the student can safely go home at the end of the day.
14. **Turn 3:** Pause: this is not your decision. Children's social care, and the police if needed, decide with the DSL. Your job is to keep the student calm and with a trusted adult.

5. **Turn 3:** Support: if a parent arrives early to collect the student, don't confront them and don't hand the student over in a rush: get the DSL or a senior leader straight away. The school has no power to keep a child from a parent. If the DSL believes the child is at immediate risk, call 999.
6. **Turn 3:** Document: add what happened at the end of the day, who decided what, and when. You never leave a step behind.

### **Afraid to go home**

A Year 9 student at 3pm: "I can't go home. He said he'd hurt me again." The example is fictional.

1. **Recognise:** A Year 9 student waits after the last lesson and says they can't go home because their stepfather said he would hurt them again. Fear of going home is a sign of immediate risk.
2. **Straight to Notify:** Go straight from Recognise to Notify: the DSL or a deputy, immediately, in person or by phone. If none can be reached, a senior leader. If the student is in immediate danger, call 999.
3. **Support:** Support: stay with the student in a safe, supervised place. "You did the right thing telling me. You're not in trouble." Don't let them leave the site alone.
4. **Engage:** Engage, while you wait: listen, use the script, and ask only what you need: "Tell me what you're worried will happen." Leave the detail to the DSL and children's social care.
5. **Pause:** Pause: don't call home to "sort it out", and don't promise the student they won't go home. You can promise that the right people are deciding now.
6. **Document:** Document: GOLD, with times. The DSL will need to share it quickly with children's social care or the police.

### **Wider spiral: siblings**

One disclosure, more than one child. A younger brother is in Year 3 at the same school, and an older sister attends another school.

1. **Three strands:** A Year 7 student discloses being hit at home. The DSL knows a younger brother attends the same school; the student mentions an older sister at another school.
2. **At the same time:** The student is supported now. The younger brother's class teacher is asked by the DSL, not by you, whether they have noticed anything. Nobody questions the younger child.
3. **Joined up:** Notify: the DSL tells children's social care about all the children in the household. Children's social care, not the school, contacts the other school or shares with its DSL as agreed.
4. **Every strand:** Every strand ends in Document. Each child has their own record, linked by the DSL.

### **When it breaks**

The same Year 7 disclosure, when steps are skipped.

1. **Recognise:** The student shows a teacher marks on their legs and says their parent used a belt. Recognise happens.
2. **Pause skipped:** The teacher takes a photo of the marks on their own phone "as evidence" and asks the student to show any others. Pause is skipped: the student is exposed and distressed, and the image is now on a personal device.
3. **Notify skipped:** The teacher phones the parent to "hear their side" instead of telling the DSL. The parent now knows the child has told, before anyone has planned for the child's safety tonight.
4. **Document skipped:** Nothing is recorded. When a sibling's teacher later raises a worry, there is nothing to connect it to.

5. **The helix fragments:** The student goes home to an angry parent and learns that telling makes things worse. They stop telling. That is how harm escalates unseen.
6. **Put it back together:** Every step taken puts the structure back. Relational is why children tell; systemic is why telling works.

The Helix is described in the RESPOND Safeguarding Operating System (section 5.2). All examples are fictional.

## R

## RECOGNISE: Notice the Signs and Hear the Disclosure

**Physical abuse at home may reach you as a clear disclosure, a visible injury, or a slow build-up of small signs. You don't need certainty, and you don't need a disclosure, to act.**

### The 4 Ps Context Scan

#### People

Who lives at home? Parents, step-parents, partners, grandparents, older siblings, an educational guardian or host family. Who else might be hurt?

#### Places

Home, the journey to and from school, weekends, exeats and holidays, including time abroad with family

#### Platforms

Marks and reports that go home through apps or email; messages from home that make the student anxious; a phone that is checked by a parent

#### Patterns

Fear around tests, reports and parents' evenings; injuries after weekends or holidays; absence after an incident. A pattern helps explain; you don't need to wait for it to happen again

### The Four Categories of Abuse (KCSIE 2026)

KCSIE 2026 defines abuse as a form of maltreatment of a child: somebody may abuse or neglect a child by inflicting harm or by failing to act to prevent harm (paragraph 25). It sets out four categories, which often overlap:

| Category                                 | In KCSIE 2026                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | How it may show up in this scenario                                                                                                      |
|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Physical abuse</b><br>(paragraph 26)  | May involve hitting, shaking, throwing, poisoning, burning or scalding, drowning, suffocating or otherwise causing physical harm to a child                                                                                                         | Being hit with a belt; marks, bruises or other injuries; fear of physical punishment                                                     |
| <b>Emotional abuse</b><br>(paragraph 27) | Persistent emotional maltreatment causing severe and adverse effects on emotional development; can include conveying that a child is valued only insofar as they meet another person's needs, and age or developmentally inappropriate expectations | Being told they are worthless or a disgrace because of their marks; constant criticism; seeing or hearing others being hurt              |
| <b>Sexual abuse</b><br>(paragraph 28)    | Forcing, causing or inciting a child to take part in sexual activities, whether or not the child is aware of what is happening; contact or non-contact, online or offline                                                                           | Not part of this disclosure, but children who experience one form of abuse may experience others. Listen for anything else they tell you |
| <b>Neglect</b><br>(paragraph 29)         | Persistent failure to meet a child's basic physical and/or psychological needs, including failing to protect a child from physical and emotional harm or danger                                                                                     | Another adult at home who knows and does not protect; the child not taken for medical care for an injury                                 |

Paraphrased from KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 25 to 29. KCSIE also notes that some level of emotional abuse is involved in all types of maltreatment (paragraph 27).

## What Physical Abuse at Home Can Look Like

### Injuries and Physical Signs

- Bruises, marks or welts, including marks in the shape of a hand or an object
- Injuries on soft or less commonly injured areas, such as the back, abdomen, buttocks, ears or neck (NSPCC Learning)
- Injuries at different stages of healing, or repeated injuries
- Explanations that don't fit the injury, change, or are very vague
- Delay in getting medical help for an injury

## Behaviour and Presentation

- Fear of going home, or of a particular adult; reluctance to take a report or test home
- Extreme anxiety about marks, mistakes or being in trouble
- Flinching, being very watchful, or wariness of adult touch
- Covering up: long sleeves or trousers in hot weather, avoiding PE changing
- Withdrawal, low mood, aggression, or sudden changes in behaviour
- Absence after a weekend, a holiday or a parents' evening

None of these signs proves abuse on its own, and many children who are hurt at home show none of them. Children with special educational needs or disabilities may be at greater risk, and an injury must never be assumed to be part of a child's condition without further exploration (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 249).

## School Events Can Be Triggers

Here the harm followed a test mark. Tests, reports, parents' evenings and sanctions sent home can be moments of risk. Keep giving honest feedback, but notice the student who dreads the report going home, and tell the DSL.

### No Disclosure Needed

Many children never say "I've been hit". They may say "My mum will kill me", refuse to change for PE, or be terrified about a mark. If you notice injuries, fear or anxiety connected to home, pass it to the DSL **without waiting for a disclosure**, and without waiting for it to happen again. Record what you saw and heard, factually.

## What the Law Says (England)

- **Physical punishment and the law in England:** a parent who hits a child may, in some cases, try to defend themselves by saying it was "reasonable punishment". Section 58 of the Children Act 2004 says that battery of a child in England **cannot** be justified as reasonable punishment where the charge is wounding or causing grievous bodily harm, assault occasioning actual bodily harm, cruelty to a person under 16, or strangulation or suffocation. In civil proceedings, battery causing actual bodily harm cannot be justified as reasonable punishment either (Children Act 2004, section 58).
- **What that means:** the defence has been narrowed, not removed, in England. It is a possible defence for the adult in a criminal case; it is **not** a threshold for safeguarding. Any physical punishment a child tells you about, with or without a mark, goes to the DSL.

- **Wales and Scotland are different:** Wales abolished the defence of reasonable punishment from 21 March 2022 (Children (Abolition of Defence of Reasonable Punishment) (Wales) Act 2020), and Scotland has also removed it (Children (Equal Protection from Assault) (Scotland) Act 2019).
- **Child protection is separate from the criminal law.** Children's social care assess whether a child is suffering, or likely to suffer, significant harm (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 69). That question does not depend on whether a crime is charged or proved.

**Staff never decide whether an offence has been committed, or whether an injury amounts to "actual bodily harm".** That is for the police and the courts. Your job is to pass the concern to the DSL. Legal references checked 28 September 2026.

## What the Data Shows

**29.0%**

of adults experienced some form of abuse before the age of 18 (about 13.6 million people)

ONS, 2025

**633,000**

referrals to children's social care in England in the year to 31 March 2025 (almost 633,000)

DfE, 2025

**230,000**

section 47 child protection enquiries in the same year (over 230,000)

DfE, 2025

**50,000**

children on child protection plans in England at 31 March 2025 (nearly 50,000)

DfE, 2025

ONS: Crime Survey for England and Wales, adults aged 18 and over, year ending March 2024; not comparable with earlier ONS figures. DfE: England, year ending 31 March 2025. For physical abuse figures, see Why This Matters. Checked 28 September 2026.

**E**

**ENGAGE: Listen, Believe, Don't Lead**

**Stay calm, listen, and believe. Use TED questions, never "why". Ask only what you need to understand the child's immediate safety: the detail belongs to children's social care and the police.**

## What a Student Might Say

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*"My dad hit me with his belt last night because I got a bad mark. Look."*

*"I fell over. It's nothing. Please don't tell anyone."*

*"Mum said if I told anyone I'd be sent away."*

*"It's my fault. I should have worked harder."*

Some children tell you directly, some test you with part of the story, and some show you an injury and say nothing. All of these go to the DSL.

## Responding in the Moment

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The **RESPOND** disclosure script:

*"I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next."*

- **TED:** "Tell me what happened." "Explain what you mean by 'he got angry'." "Describe where you are hurt now."
- "Are you hurt anywhere now that needs looking after?" "How are you feeling about going home today?"
- "Is there anyone else at home you're worried about?" (brothers, sisters, another adult)
- Use their words. If they say "Dad" or "the belt", write that; don't change it to "parent" or "implement" in your notes.
- **If they show you an injury:** look at what they have chosen to show you, stay calm, and don't ask them to show you anything else, move clothing, or undress.
- **If they take it back** ("I made it up, forget it"): stay calm, don't argue, and still pass on everything you saw and heard. Retraction is common when a child is frightened.

### Helpful

- "Thank you for telling me. You've done the right thing."
- "Nobody is allowed to hurt you, whatever your marks are."
- "It's not your fault."
- Reflect back: "So after you got the test back, your dad..."
- Minimal encouragers: "Go on." "I'm listening."

### Unhelpful

- "Why did he hit you?" or "What did you do?" (why questions feel like blame)
- "Did your dad do this with his belt?" before they have said so (leading)
- "I'm sure he didn't mean it." "Lots of parents smack." (minimising)
- "Let me see the rest." or "Can I take a photo?" (examining, recording images)
- "I'll call your mum and sort this out." (can increase the risk)
- "I won't tell anyone, I promise." (a promise you cannot keep)

### If You Witness a Child Being Hurt or Threatened

If you see a parent or carer hitting, grabbing or threatening a child on site, for example at pick-up or a school event, act **if it is safe to do so**, using the 4Ds: **Direct** ("Let's all take a moment. Can I help?"), **Distract** (give the child a reason to come with you), **Delegate** (send for the DSL or a senior leader; call 999 if anyone is in immediate danger), **Delay** (check in with the child as soon as it is safe). Don't put yourself at risk or get into a confrontation. Then tell the DSL straight away.

## S

### SUPPORT: Safety First, Today

**Your first job is the student's safety today: their body, their feelings, and the end of the school day. Your calm is contagious.**

## Safety Check Questions

### Hurt Now

- "Are you hurt anywhere now? Does anything need looking after?"
- If an injury needs first aid, a first aider or the school nurse treats it as they would any injury. They don't examine it for evidence.
- If the child needs urgent medical care, call 999 or arrange for them to go to A&E, and tell the DSL straight away.

## Going Home

- "How are you feeling about going home today?"
- "Who will be at home tonight?" "Who is collecting you?"
- Tell the DSL exactly what the child says about going home, in their words.

## Injuries: What You Don't Do

- **Don't photograph injuries**, on any device, school or personal. Images of a child's body must not be taken by staff.
- **Don't examine** the child, touch the injury, or ask them to undress or move clothing to show you more.
- **Record what you saw in words**, including where on the body (see Document).
- **The DSL arranges any medical assessment**, through children's social care and health services. Where there is reasonable cause to suspect significant harm, health practitioners may carry out a child protection medical as part of the multi-agency response (Working Together 2026).

## Immediate Support

- A private, quiet space where you can still be seen by others; water; time; the option not to go straight back to a lesson
- Stay with the student, or make sure a trusted adult does, while you tell the DSL. Don't leave them alone and upset
- "You've done the right thing by telling me. This is not your fault."
- "You're not in trouble. The adults here are going to help."
- Connection before correction: if the student is distressed, angry or refuses to go to class, this is not the moment for sanctions

## SEND, Neurodivergence and Language

- Allow extra processing time and a quiet space. Use short, concrete questions; avoid idioms and double questions.
- Offer other ways to communicate: drawing, writing, a symbol board, or the student's usual communication aid. Record how the student communicated.
- Don't assume a mark or a behaviour is part of a child's condition (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 249). Involve the SENCO through the DSL.

- Where English is not the student's first language, the DSL arranges a professional interpreter. **Never use a family member, another student or a friend of the family to interpret** (Working Together 2026).

### Brothers, Sisters and Other Children

Other children in the household may be at risk too. Working Together 2026 says that when emergency action is considered, the needs of other children in the same household, or in the household of the person alleged to have caused harm, should always be considered. Tell the DSL about any siblings you know of. **Don't question them yourself**, and don't ask the student to watch out for them or report back: that is not a child's job.

## **P** PAUSE: Consider Your Approach

Act with composure. Take 90 seconds: breathe, lower your shoulders, check your own state. The Pause stops you doing something well-meant that makes things worse, such as calling home.

## Three Lenses

| Lens      | In this scenario                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|-----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Risk      | Is the student hurt now? Are they safe to go home today? Has the adult threatened them for telling? Are other children at home at risk? Is anyone in immediate danger (999)?                                   |
| Rights    | The student's right to be safe, to be believed, to be heard, and to be told honestly what happens next; their right to have their views considered in the plan; their dignity (no examination, no photographs) |
| Resources | The DSL and deputies, the school nurse or first aider, children's social care (including the emergency duty team out of hours), the police, health services, and the safe adults in the student's life         |

## What You Must Not Do

### Don't Investigate

- Don't ask for every detail, or ask the student to go through it again for someone else

- Don't ask leading questions, speak to siblings or friends, or check social media
- Children's social care and the police may need to interview the child; repeated questioning can make that harder

### **Don't Contact the Parents**

- Don't phone, email or message home, or mention it at pick-up
- The DSL decides, with children's social care and the police, who tells the parents, what and when
- An early call can put the child, and other children at home, at greater risk

### **Don't Promise Secrecy**

*"I'm really glad you've told me. I can't keep this to myself, because I'm worried about your safety. I'm going to tell our safeguarding lead, whose job is to keep you safe. I'll only tell people who need to know, and I'll tell you what's happening."*

### **Don't Decide It Is Discipline, Culture or a One-Off**

- "It's how they do things in their culture", "they're under a lot of pressure" or "it only happened once" can explain; they never excuse harm to a child
- Staff never decide whether an offence was committed or whether punishment was "reasonable"
- Pass it on, and let the DSL and other agencies assess it

## **Check Your Own Response**

- Notice your reactions: anger with the parent, shock, disbelief, or a wish to rescue the child
- Be aware of your own experience of physical punishment as a child or a parent, and how it may shape what feels "normal" to you
- Avoid the rescuer mindset: you can't promise the child what will happen, but you can promise to pass it to people who can help

- If you feel overwhelmed: "This is important and I want to get it right. Can you wait here with [named adult] for a few minutes while I speak to the DSL?"



## OFFER: Model Alternatives

**Offer proportionate options without coercion, explain honestly what happens next, and show the student, by how you respond, that adults can deal with mistakes without hurting. If in doubt, N before O: in this scenario, tell the DSL first.**

### Explain What Happens Next

*"Here's what happens now. I'm going to talk to our safeguarding lead straight away. Their job is to keep you safe. They'll want to talk with you today, and I can be there if you'd like. They may need to talk to other people whose job is to help children, like a social worker. We won't phone home without thinking carefully first about how to keep you safe. You're not in trouble, and nobody here is angry with you. What would you like to ask me?"*

Be honest about information sharing. Staff should share safeguarding information as early as possible, and data protection law does not prevent it; safeguarding children is a lawful basis for sharing sensitive information without consent where appropriate (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 142 to 148). What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. From 30 September 2026, the Information Sharing Duty (section 16LA, Children Act 2004) also requires the organisations it covers to share where its tests are met; the DSL decides how it applies. So don't ask for consent as if it were the legal basis. Tell the student what will be shared, with whom and why, unless that would increase the risk, and listen to their views: they shape the plan. Agreeing to a service, such as counselling, is a separate question, and their agreement matters there.

Be honest about what you don't know. Don't promise that the student will or won't go home, that their parent won't find out, or that the police won't be involved. You can promise that the student will be kept informed and listened to.

### Options, Not Orders

- "Would you like me to stay with you when you talk to the safeguarding lead?"
- "Would you like to wait here, or somewhere else quiet?"
- "What would help you feel a bit safer right now?"

Some things have to happen to keep the student safe. Where there is a choice, give it to them.

## Model the Alternative

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### What the Student Sees From You

- A calm adult who believes them
- Mistakes and poor marks met with help, not punishment
- Honesty about what happens next
- Respect for their body and their privacy

### What They May Have Learned at Home

- Mistakes lead to pain or fear
- Adults are unpredictable
- Telling makes things worse
- It is their fault

Every calm, consistent response from staff chips away at the second list. Around marks and feedback, **connection before correction**: praise effort, frame mistakes as part of learning, and be thoughtful about how messages go home. Relationships education that covers being safe and how to report abuse belongs in the curriculum for everyone (RSHE statutory guidance).

## Support in School and Beyond

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- A named trusted adult and a daily check-in, agreed with the student
- The school nurse or counsellor, if the student wants that (agreeing to a service is their choice)
- The tutor made aware, without details, so they can support
- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7

# N

## NOTIFY: Tell the DSL Now

**Tell the DSL as soon as is practicably possible, and in this scenario that means straight away, before the student goes home. You don't need certainty: you need to share what you saw and heard. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.**

### Who and When

- Find the DSL or a deputy in person or by phone: "I need to speak to you now. A student has told me they were hit at home last night and has shown me marks on their legs."
- Don't send it only by email or put it only on the system and hope it is seen. Speak to someone, then record it.
- If the DSL and deputies can't be reached, this must not delay action: go to a senior leader, or take advice from children's social care (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 61). Don't wait until the end of the day: the decision about going home needs time.
- If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.
- Anyone can refer directly to children's social care if they believe a child is at risk; telling the DSL does not remove your own responsibility. Staff should not assume a colleague will act (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 62).

## What to Tell the DSL

- What the student said, in their words, and what you asked
- What you saw: the marks, where on the body, and roughly how they looked, in words
- When and where it happened, and who they said did it, if they told you
- Whether the student is hurt now or needs medical attention
- What the student said about going home today, and who is collecting them
- Any threats about telling, and any other children at home
- Anything you had noticed before, such as worry about marks or covering up
- Where the student is now, and who is with them

### ▼ For the DSL: assessment, external agencies and parents

Most staff need only: tell the DSL, today, with the information above.

## The DSL's Initial Actions

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- Check immediate safety: medical needs, immediate danger (999), and the end of the school day
- Where a child is suffering or likely to suffer harm, refer to children's social care, and the police if appropriate, immediately, following the local referral process (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 65). Out of hours, use the local authority's emergency duty team
- Decide with children's social care, and the police where involved, whether and how parents are told, before anyone contacts them
- Agree the plan for going home: the aim is a decision the same day, before the end of the school day where possible. Emergency protective action is taken by the police (police powers of protection) or through a court order (an Emergency Protection Order), not by the school (Working Together 2026)
- Identify other children in the household, at this school or elsewhere, and tell children's social care about them
- Where the Information Sharing Duty applies (from 30 September 2026), apply its three tests: share information that is relevant to safeguarding or promoting the child's welfare (Relevance) and may help the recipient to safeguard or promote their welfare (May facilitate), unless sharing would be more detrimental to the child than not sharing (Detriment), which applies only in extremely limited circumstances; record the decision to share or not share, with the rationale, and be transparent with the young person unless that would increase the risk. Data protection law still applies to how information is shared (Information Sharing Duty statutory guidance)
- Record on the safeguarding system, with a chronology linking any earlier concerns

## What May Happen Next (in General Terms)

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- **Referral:** children's social care acknowledge the referral and decide the type of response within one working day (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 70). Where siblings attend other schools, children's social care decide how those schools are informed.
- **Strategy discussion:** whenever there is reasonable cause to suspect a child is suffering or likely to suffer significant harm, there should be a strategy discussion. As a minimum it involves a local authority social worker, health practitioners and a police representative; the referring school may be invited. It shares information, agrees the conduct and timing of any criminal investigation, and informs the local authority's decision on section 47 enquiries.
- **Section 47 enquiries** (Children Act 1989): the local authority's enquiries to decide whether, and what, action is needed to safeguard a child who is suspected to be suffering, or likely to suffer, significant harm. The lead social worker should see the child alone to understand their wishes and feelings, and explain the process to parents unless that would affect the child's safety and welfare.

- **Initial child protection conference:** where concerns are substantiated and the child is judged to be suffering or likely to suffer significant harm, a conference should take place within 15 working days of the strategy discussion. The school may be asked for a report and to attend.
- **Child protection plan or child in need plan,** or other support, depending on the outcome. A decision not to pursue a criminal investigation does not decide whether a child has suffered significant harm.

Summarised from Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026 and KCSIE 2026 (paragraphs 69 and 70). Local procedures set out the detail.

### Operation Encompass

Since November 2025, the police have a statutory duty to notify a child's education setting, and where relevant the local authority, if they have reasonable grounds to believe the child may be a victim of domestic abuse (KCSIE 2026, Annex A). A notification about this student or a sibling is information the DSL links to this concern.

### Where a Student Is 18

At 18 a student is legally an adult. The child safeguarding framework in KCSIE applies to under-18s, but the school still has welfare responsibilities. Where an 18-year-old is involved, the DSL considers adult safeguarding, police and welfare pathways alongside the school's procedures, and the adult student's own views and consent in a different way. This matters in sixth form and in boarding, where students turn 18 during their final year.

### Parents and Carers: What the DSL Tells Them, and When

Usually schools work in partnership with parents. Here, the parent may be the source of the harm. The DSL does not tell parents before agreeing the approach with children's social care, and the police where involved, because telling them could put the child at greater risk, lead to pressure on the child to retract, or affect a police investigation. Working Together 2026 says the lead social worker decides what information is shared with the child and family, and that information is not shared if this may jeopardise a police investigation or place the child at risk of harm. Record who decided what, and why.

Where children's social care advise the school to speak to parents, plan who, when and what the student has been told; keep to the facts and don't debate whether the punishment was reasonable.

### If the DSL is advised to speak to a parent

- "We need to talk to you about [name]. [Name] came to school today with injuries, and we have shared our concern with children's social care, as we must."
- "We're not able to go into detail. A social worker will be in touch with you."
- "Our focus is on [name]'s safety and wellbeing, and on supporting your family."
- If a parent becomes angry or threatening, end the conversation calmly, and seek advice from children's social care or the police about the child's safety that evening.

### Communication and Devices

Assume that anything sent home, or to the student's phone or school account, may be seen by the adult who hurt them. Don't send messages about the concern to the student's personal device or a shared family email, and check that no automated message (for example, an absence text) could reveal what has happened before the plan allows.

## **D** DOCUMENT: Record Observations

Record as soon as is practicably possible, on the school's safeguarding system, using **GOLD**. In this scenario, write it straight after you have spoken to the DSL. Your record may be read by children's social care, the police and the courts.

### **GOLD**

#### **Ground**

Date, time, place, who was present, who you are, and how it came to your attention

#### **Observe**

What you saw and heard, with exact words in quotation marks

#### **Language**

Neutral, factual and non-diagnostic. No opinions or labels

#### **Do**

What you did, what you said would happen next, and why

## Example: Exact Words and What You Saw

- Student said: "My dad hit me with his belt last night because I got a bad mark in maths."
- Student said: "He said if I get another bad mark it'll be worse."
- Student said: "Please don't tell my mum I told you."
- Observed: the student pulled up the left leg of their trousers. Three red lines, each about the length of my hand, across the back of the left thigh, above the knee. I did not look at any other area.
- Observed: tearful, spoke quietly, and asked twice whether they would have to go home.

## Recording Marks on the Body: a Body Map in Words

Many schools use a body map form. Whether or not yours does, describe what you saw in words, and only what you saw. Don't look for more.

| Record                                         | Example                                                                                                 |
|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Where on the body, and which side              | "Back of the left thigh, just above the knee"; "outer right upper arm"                                  |
| Front or back, and the student's left or right | Use the student's left and right, not yours, and say so                                                 |
| What you saw                                   | Colour, shape, number and approximate size (for example, "about 10cm long" or "the size of a 50p coin") |
| How you came to see it                         | "The student rolled up their trouser leg to show me"; "visible below the sleeve during the lesson"      |
| What the student said about it                 | Their exact words, in quotation marks, including any explanation                                        |
| What you did not do                            | "I did not examine, touch or photograph the injury"                                                     |

Don't diagnose or date injuries ("an old bruise", "belt marks") unless you are quoting the student. Write "The student said the marks were from a belt."

### Recording template

SAFEGUARDING CONCERN: DISCLOSURE OF PHYSICAL HARM AT HOME

Date and time of disclosure:

Student: name, year, tutor group

Recorded by: name and role

Where and how it came to your attention:

WHAT THE STUDENT SAID (exact words in quotation marks):

WHAT I ASKED (exact questions):

WHAT I SAW (body map in words: location, side, colour, shape, size; how I

came to see it):

I did not examine, touch or photograph any injury: yes / no (explain)

ANY MEDICAL NEED AND WHAT WAS DONE:

WHAT THE STUDENT SAID ABOUT GOING HOME TODAY:

OTHER CHILDREN IN THE HOUSEHOLD (if mentioned):

ANY EARLIER CONCERNS I AM AWARE OF:

WHAT I DID AND SAID (with times):

SHARED WITH: DSL or deputy (name, time, how)

THE STUDENT'S VIEWS AND WISHES:

Signed and dated:

### What Not to Record

- Opinions about the parent or the family ("a strict household", "a lovely family")
- Assumptions about culture, faith or nationality, or about what is "normal" discipline
- Diagnoses or guesses about how or when an injury happened
- Whether you think an offence has been committed
- Photographs or drawings of the child's body, other than marking a location on the school's body map form if it uses one

## Boarding and Residential Life

For boarders, school is also home, and harm at home may surface after an exeat, a holiday or a phone call. The next journey home may be only days away.

| Step               | In boarding                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ● <b>Recognise</b> | Use the 4 Ps for home and away: exeats and holidays; weekends with a guardian or host family; distressing calls home; anxiety before reports go home. Notice injuries or fear after a return.                                    |
| ● <b>Engage</b>    | Boarders often tell house staff at quiet times, such as bedtime or after a phone call home. Use TED and the script. Talk in a visible space and let another adult know.                                                          |
| ● <b>Support</b>   | Safety tonight and at the next exeat or holiday: is the boarder due to go home, or to a guardian, soon? Is a parent visiting? Tell the DSL at once; travel plans may need to be reviewed by the DSL with children's social care. |
| ● <b>Pause</b>     | Don't contact parents, guardians or host families yourself, and don't investigate. If there is immediate risk, don't wait until morning.                                                                                         |

| Step       | In boarding                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ● Offer    | Model alternatives: house staff who respond to mistakes calmly and fairly. If in doubt, N before O.                                                                                                   |
| ● Notify   | Contact the on-call DSL or boarding deputy DSL straight away. If a child is in immediate danger and no DSL can be reached, call 999; out of hours, contact the local authority's emergency duty team. |
| ● Document | Record on the safeguarding system before you go off duty, using GOLD and a body map in words. A house log or handover note is not a substitute.                                                       |

### International Families, Parents Abroad and Guardians

- Harm may have happened at home abroad, during a holiday, or with an educational guardian or host family in the UK. Pass it on in the same way: children's social care in the school's area advise on what happens next.
- The DSL decides, with children's social care, whether, when and how parents abroad are contacted, and in what language, using a professional interpreter where needed. Time zones never justify delay in telling the DSL.
- Whether a guardian is appointed by the school or the parents, the school takes appropriate steps to ensure the arrangement promotes the boarder's welfare; any concern about it should be acted on immediately and referred to the relevant agencies; school staff should not be appointed as educational guardians for boarders (NMS 2026, Standard 22).
- Some homestay arrangements may amount to private fostering, which the local authority must be told about (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 416 and 417). The DSL checks.

### Boarders' Routes to Help

- **Boarders can always contact their house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.** Make sure every boarder knows how.
- An independent person outside the staff whom boarders can contact directly (NMS 11.4), often called the independent listener
- Boarders must be able to contact their families privately; monitoring of communications should be proportionate (NMS 12.1)
- International boarders: agree with the DSL who contacts parents or guardians, when, and in what language, using interpreters where needed

Source: National Minimum Standards for Boarding Schools (2026).

## Identity and Intersecting Harm

- **Culture, faith and discipline:** physical punishment may be common or legal where a family comes from. Understanding that helps you respond well; it never lowers the response. Working Together 2026 asks practitioners to understand families' background, ethnicity and religion, and to be mindful of negative stereotypes, while staying alert to where children may be experiencing abuse as a result of the actions of parents or carers.
- **Abuse linked to faith or belief**, such as allegations that a child is possessed, can include physical harm. Working Together 2026 names it. Tell the DSL straight away.
- **Disability and communication needs:** disabled children and children with SEND can face extra barriers to being recognised and heard, including assumptions that injuries or behaviour relate to their condition (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 249). A child who can't easily tell you may show you, or show it in their behaviour.
- **Race and stereotypes** can affect whose injuries are noticed, whose account is believed, and which families are assumed to be "strict" or "fine". Check whether assumptions about the student or the family are shaping your response, in either direction.
- **Language:** use professional interpreters. **Never ask a family member, a family friend or another student to interpret;** Working Together 2026 says practitioners should not need to rely on family members or partners for interpretation, including British Sign Language.
- **LGBTQ+ young people** may face harm at home connected to their identity, and may fear what telling will reveal. Don't assume, and don't share more than is needed with the family.

## Additional Resources and Support

### For Students

- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **For under-18s, start here.**
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- Childline: physical abuse, and Childline: cover your tracks (visiting help websites more privately)
- Emergency: 999

### For Parents and Carers

- NSPCC Helpline: 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or [help@nspcc.org.uk](mailto:help@nspcc.org.uk), for adults worried about a child
- YoungMinds Parents Helpline: 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)
- National Domestic Abuse Helpline (Refuge, for adults): 0808 2000 247, free, 24 hours
- For a parent or carer who is not the source of harm and is worried about their child. This scenario has no parent guide: the adults at home may be the source of the harm.

### For Staff

- NSPCC Learning, *Protecting children from physical abuse*
- NSPCC Helpline: 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or [help@nspcc.org.uk](mailto:help@nspcc.org.uk), for adults worried about a child
- Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff

## Statutory Guidance and Law

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- Department for Education, *Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026*
- HM Government, *Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026* (published 18 March 2026)
- Department for Education, *Information Sharing Duty: statutory guidance* (in force 30 September 2026)
- Department for Education, *RSHE statutory guidance* (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026)
- Department for Education, *National minimum standards for boarding schools* (2026)
- Children Act 2004, section 58 (reasonable punishment: England)
- Children (Abolition of Defence of Reasonable Punishment) (Wales) Act 2020
- Children (Equal Protection from Assault) (Scotland) Act 2019, section 1

## Figures

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- Office for National Statistics, *Abuse during childhood in England and Wales: year ending March 2024* (published 5 November 2025)
- Department for Education, *Children in need: reporting year 2025* (published 30 October 2025)

Contacts, figures and legal references checked 28 September 2026. Verify at point of use.

## Quick Reference Card

### Immediate Danger Comes First

**Immediate danger or possible risk to life:** call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response.

### Recognise

- Injuries, especially patterned marks or marks on soft areas
- Fear of going home, or of marks and reports going home
- Covering up, flinching, anxiety about mistakes
- No disclosure needed, and no need to wait for it to happen again

### Respond

- "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- TED, never "why"; no leading questions
- No photographs, no examining, no asking to see more
- Don't promise secrecy; don't contact the parents

### Notify

- DSL straight away, in person, before the student goes home
- The DSL decides about going home, the same day
- Immediate danger: 999
- If in doubt, N before O

### Document

- GOLD: Ground, Observe, Language, Do
- Exact words; marks described in words: where, which side, what you saw

- No opinions about the family, no diagnosis

### Key Numbers

- Emergency: 999; police non-emergency: 101
- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- NSPCC Helpline: 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or [help@nspcc.org.uk](mailto:help@nspcc.org.uk), for adults worried about a child
- Out of hours: the local authority's emergency duty team
- Your DSL: named in the school's safeguarding policy

### Online Evidence: One Rule

- **Ordinary messages or posts a student has already shown you:** note what is relevant (platform, date, who, exact words) in your record. Don't ask to see more or scroll through a phone, especially where messages may be sexual, because they may contain images. Don't log in to accounts, search profiles or investigate, and never transfer anything to a personal device.
- **Nude or semi-nude images of anyone under 18:** don't intentionally view, copy, screenshot, forward, save or delete them. Tell the DSL straight away. If you see one by accident, tell the DSL, ask for support if you need it, and record that it was seen and what you did, without describing the image (UKCIS).
- The DSL decides what happens to devices and content.

## Your School's Contacts

This guide is generic. Schools add their own details here, or keep a completed copy with this card, so that anyone responding, including at night, has the routes to hand.

| Contact                                                | Name and how to reach them |
|--------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)                     |                            |
| Deputy DSL(s)                                          |                            |
| Out-of-hours and boarding on-call safeguarding contact |                            |
| How to record a concern (system or form)               |                            |
| Local authority children's services front door         |                            |
| Out-of-hours emergency duty team                       |                            |
| LADO (concerns about adults)                           |                            |
| Police: 999 (emergency); 101 (non-emergency)           |                            |

### **RESPOND** Safeguarding Framework Reference Scenarios · Staff Guide 6

#### Scenario 6: Student Discloses Abuse at Home

© 2026/27 | **RESPOND** Safeguarding Framework

Aligned with: KCSIE 2026 | Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026 | Information Sharing Duty (September 2026) | Children Act 2004, section 58 | RSHE statutory guidance (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026) | NMS for Boarding Schools 2026

Last Updated: September 2026 | Next Review: September 2027, or on publication of KCSIE 2027 if sooner

For staff in schools and other settings working with children. You may share it with colleagues. Share the student guides, not this page, with students.